COLOSSIANS · STUDY 11 OF 12

Colossians 4:2–6

Perfecting the Prayer Life

Christ Is All — A Study of Colossians

Small Group Bible Study Series · NASB95

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① Text	② Devotional	③ Commentary	④ Self-Study Guide
Foundation	Personal preparation	Teacher / leader preparation	Group meeting
Everyone	*All group members*	*Teacher / leader*	*Small group*

⑤ *Application closes each study and draws from all sections above.*

Time guide: about 30 minutes — Devotional 4 · Commentary 15 · Discussion 8 · Application 3.

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① BIBLICAL TEXT

Colossians 4:2–6 · New American Standard Bible (NASB95)

4:2 *Devote yourselves to prayer, keeping alert in it with an attitude of thanksgiving;*

3 *praying at the same time for us as well, that God will open up to us a door for the word, so that we may speak forth the mystery of Christ, for which I have also been imprisoned;*

4 *that I may make it clear in the way I ought to speak.*

5 *Conduct yourselves with wisdom toward outsiders, making the most of the opportunity.*

6 *Let your speech always be with grace, as though seasoned with salt, so that you will know how you should respond to each person.*

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② DEVOTIONAL

Personal preparation · Drawn from the outline of this study

Pray, Walk, Talk

> *“Devote yourselves to prayer, keeping alert in it with an attitude of thanksgiving”*
> *— Colossians 4:2 (NASB95)*

Paul has prayed for the Colossians (1:3, 9). Now he asks them to pray, for themselves, and for him. And the man asking is in chains. He does not ask for his chains to come off. He asks for a door to open for the gospel and for the words to make Christ clear.

Prayer is not a luxury for the spiritually advanced; it is as necessary as breathing. Paul calls us to devote ourselves to it, to stay alert in it, and to season it with thanksgiving. Watch before you pray, while you pray, and after you pray, looking for God's answer.

Then he turns from our prayers to our walk and our talk. Live wisely toward those outside the faith. Buy up every opportunity. Let your words be gracious and seasoned with salt, so you will know how to answer each person. The doors God opens through prayer, He expects us to walk through with wisdom and grace.

For reflection

1. Is your prayer life more like breathing or more like an emergency kit you open only in a crisis?
2. Who in your life might God be opening a door for you to speak with about Christ?
3. Would the people outside the church who know you best describe your speech as gracious?

Inhale by prayer, exhale by thanksgiving, and walk through the doors God opens.

③ COMMENTARY

Teacher preparation resource · Full text organized under outline headings

> **The passage teaches:** Believers must devote themselves to alert, thankful prayer, including prayer for open doors and clear proclamation of the gospel, and must conduct themselves wisely toward outsiders, making the most of every opportunity with gracious, well-seasoned speech that knows how to answer each person.

Outline

- **I. Supplication (4:2)**
  - A. A Devoted Habit (4:2a)
  - B. A Guarded Habit (4:2b)
  - C. A Grateful Habit (4:2c)
- **II. Presentation (4:3–4)**
  - A. The Chance: An Open Door (4:3a)
  - B. The Communication (4:3b)
  - C. The Complication (4:3c)
  - D. The Charge (4:4)
- **III. Implementation (4:5)**
  - A. Guarding Our Testimony (4:5a)
  - B. Guarding Our Time (4:5b)
- **IV. Conversation (4:6)**
  - A. Adding Sweetness: Speech with Grace (4:6a)
  - B. Adding Seasoning: Speech Seasoned with Salt (4:6b)
  - C. Adding Scripture: Knowing How to Answer (4:6c)

Introduction

Paul has already told the Colossians how he prays for them (1:3, 9). Now he asks them to pray, and he asks them to pray for him. His primary concern in this passage is prayer in connection with evangelism. He wants the Colossians to pray (v.2). He wants them to pray specifically for his gospel ministry (vv.3–4). And he wants them to be wise in their own witness (vv.5–6). We may follow the passage under four headings: supplication, presentation, implementation, and conversation.

I. Supplication (4:2)

A. A Devoted Habit (4:2a)

"Devote yourselves to prayer." The verb (*proskartereō*) means to persist in, to be busily engaged in, to hold fast to something. It is used of the early church, which was "continually devoting themselves … to prayer" (Acts 2:42). Paul himself was a man of prayer, and he knew its value, so he wanted the prayers of others.

Prayer is not a spiritual luxury; it is an absolute necessity. It is as vital for spiritual health as breathing is for physical health. It must be continuous, and it must be earnest. In prayer we call on God to work, and we express our faith in Him. It follows that a believer who does not pray is demonstrating independence from God. Jesus said:

> *“I am the vine, you are the branches; he who abides in Me and I in him, he bears much fruit, for apart from Me you can do nothing.”*
>
> — John 15:5 (NASB95)

B. A Guarded Habit (4:2b)

"Keeping alert in it." The word (*grēgoreō*) means to stay awake, be watchful. Paul would have known how Jesus used the same word with His sleepy disciples in Gethsemane:

> *“And He came to the disciples and found them sleeping, and said to Peter, “So, you men could not keep watch with Me for one hour? Keep watching and praying that you may not enter into temptation; the spirit is willing, but the flesh is weak.””*
>
> — Matthew 26:40–41 (NASB95)

1. Watch before you pray

Do not rush into His presence unprepared or distracted, and do not let the enemy spoil your spirit before you begin. Satan does not want you to pray. As William Cowper wrote, "Satan trembles when he sees / The weakest saint upon his knees."

2. Watch while you pray

Watch, lest a wandering thought slip in and distract you from this important meeting with the Ruler of the universe. Take "every thought captive to the obedience of Christ" (2 Cor. 10:5).

3. Watch after you pray

Look out confidently for the answer. The possible answers are more than "yes" and "no." "No" is an answer, but delay is not always "no." The answer may be "wait." Keep praying! And when the answer is "no," view it against this threefold background: His love wants the best for you; His wisdom knows the best for you; His power gets the best for you.

Does this sound complicated? We are not left alone in it:

> *“In the same way the Spirit also helps our weakness; for we do not know how to pray as we should, but the Spirit Himself intercedes for us with groanings too deep for words;”*
>
> — Romans 8:26 (NASB95)

C. A Grateful Habit (4:2c)

"With an attitude of thanksgiving." Remember what your mother used to say when someone gave you something? "What do you say?" And you would sheepishly answer, "Thank you." Paul reminds the Colossians to express gratitude always in view of God's goodness and grace. J. Vernon McGee put it this way: prayer and thanksgiving are like breathing; inhale by prayer, exhale by thanksgiving.

Paul's frequent calls to thanksgiving make Colossians one of the most thankful books in the New Testament (1:3, 12; 2:7; 3:15, 16, 17; 4:2).

II. Presentation (4:3–4)

"Praying at the same time for us as well." Paul turns to his own request, and it is entirely about the gospel.

A. The Chance: An Open Door (4:3a)

"That God will open up to us a door for the word." Paul's commission was to take the gospel to the Gentiles, and he was in prison. Yet he was still looking for opportunities to spread the message, perhaps among the palace guard and Caesar's own household (Phil. 1:13; 4:22).

There is an old story of an eager boy applying for a job. The employer asked, "Do you have a motto in life?" "Yes, sir," the boy said, "same as yours." "What do you mean?" "I saw it on your door, sir: Push." That may be a good motto for business, but it will not do for gospel ministry. Too many mistakes have been made, and too many lives spoiled, by trying to push doors open.

Paul himself learned this. On his second journey he and his companions were "forbidden by the Holy Spirit to speak the word in Asia," and when they tried to go into Bithynia, "the Spirit of Jesus did not permit them" (Acts 16:6–7). Asia was closed for the moment; Europe was God's door. We should not try to manufacture opportunities for Christian service, but we should be eager to take them when God provides them. Here Paul prefers praying to pushing. After all, God is the expert in doors:

> *""And to the angel of the church in Philadelphia write:*
> *He who is holy, who is true, who has the key of David, who opens and no one will shut, and who shuts and no one opens, says this: 'I know your deeds. Behold, I have put before you an open door which no one can shut, because you have a little power, and have kept My word, and have not denied My name."*
>
> — Revelation 3:7–8 (NASB95)

B. The Communication (4:3b)

"So that we may speak forth the mystery of Christ." Paul wanted opportunities to make Christ known. "The mystery of Christ" is the gospel as revealed to Paul, including the truth that Gentiles are fellow heirs in one body (1:26–27; Eph. 3:4–6). What did he do with those opportunities? First, he did not miss them; he was watching for them and expecting them. Second, he took advantage of them.

C. The Complication (4:3c)

"For which I have also been imprisoned." His chains were the result of preaching this very message. Yet in Philippians, the last of the prison letters, Paul explains how God used it all:

> *"Now I want you to know, brethren, that my circumstances have turned out for the greater progress of the gospel, so that my imprisonment in the cause of Christ has become well known throughout the whole praetorian guard and to everyone else,"*
>
> — Philippians 1:12–13 (NASB95)

Everyone in the palace guard knew Paul was not a criminal. His chains were "in Christ."

D. The Charge (4:4)

"That I may make it clear in the way I ought to speak." The phrase "I ought" (*dei*) expresses necessity: as it is necessary for me to speak. Paul did not see preaching as an option. Compare 1 Corinthians 9:16:

> *“For if I preach the gospel, I have nothing to boast of, for I am under compulsion; for woe is me if I do not preach the gospel.”*
>
> — 1 Corinthians 9:16 (NASB95)

He asks for clarity, not cleverness. The goal was to "make it clear," to make Christ plain.

III. Implementation (4:5)

A. Guarding Our Testimony (4:5a)

"Conduct yourselves with wisdom toward outsiders." The word is literally "walk" (*peripateite*), our lifestyle, what our daily walking around looks like to people outside the church. A line often credited to Ralph Waldo Emerson says, "What you do speaks so loudly that I cannot hear what you say."

Some believers who have the truth try to beat people over the head with it. They are boorish in their approach, and that is not wisdom. If we display the right character, say the right words, recognize the right time, and use the right tact, we will draw people in rather than push them away. And wisdom is available. Christ "became to us wisdom from God" (1 Cor. 1:30), and God gives wisdom generously to all who ask (James 1:5).

B. Guarding Our Time (4:5b)

"Making the most of the opportunity." The verb (*exagorazomenoi*) means to buy up, to redeem from the marketplace. The word for "opportunity" (*kairos*) is not clock time but the right moment, the opening. We need to buy up every opportunity to bring people to Christ. Don't pass them by. Each one is not merely an opportunity; it is a person for whom Christ died. We may be the last believer to speak to that person. So we must "be ready in season and out of season" (2 Tim. 4:2).

IV. Conversation (4:6)

Paul turns from our walk to our talk.

A. Adding Sweetness: Speech with Grace (4:6a)

"Let your speech always be with grace." Our speech should be gracious, pleasant, and kind. Don't get in the way of what God wants to do for that person. It is a matter of life and death, eternal life and death.

B. Adding Seasoning: Speech Seasoned with Salt (4:6b)

"As though seasoned with salt." Salt has many uses. It preserves, it purifies, it makes food appealing, and it can sting. Paul probably means speech that is wholesome and attractive, not bland. Occasionally it may call for a sharper word. Jesus could call the Pharisees a "brood of vipers" (Matt. 12:34), but most often He spoke words of grace to those who would receive grace. Even the officers sent to arrest Him reported, "Never has a man spoken the way this man speaks" (John 7:46). McGee observed that a child of God's conversation should restrain evil rather than promote it, and added that a Christian should not be boring.

C. Adding Scripture: Knowing How to Answer (4:6c)

"So that you will know how you should respond to each person." Notice "each person." Witness is personal; one answer does not fit everyone. Knowing how to respond requires knowing the Word, not just listening to sermons but studying and using it. How do we answer those who ask? With the Word, "the sword of the Spirit" (Eph. 6:17). Jesus answered each of Satan's temptations with Scripture (Matt. 4:1–11):

- "Man shall not live on bread alone, but on every word that proceeds out of the mouth of God" (Matt. 4:4, quoting Deut. 8:3).
- "You shall not put the Lord your God to the test" (Matt. 4:7, quoting Deut. 6:16).
- "You shall worship the Lord your God, and serve Him only" (Matt. 4:10, quoting Deut. 6:13).

Peter gives the same counsel: "always being ready to make a defense to everyone who asks you to give an account for the hope that is in you, yet with gentleness and reverence" (1 Pet. 3:15).

Conclusion

Paul's plan for evangelism begins on our knees: devoted, alert, thankful prayer, including prayer for open doors and clear words. It continues in our walk: wise conduct toward outsiders and the purchase of every opportunity. And it is carried in our talk: speech full of grace, seasoned with salt, and ready with the Word for each person.

Pick out one person in your mind right now, and say to the Lord, "I will pray for him," or "I will pray for her." Then pray for an open door, and watch for it.

Lord, thank You.

④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE

For use during the group meeting · Focused on the commentary text

Greek Word Study

Grammar and parsing: Blue Letter Bible. Sources cited selectively: STR (Strong's), THAY (Thayer's), ATR (A. T. Robertson), VINE (Vine's), MRV (Vincent's), LXX (Septuagint usage).

Verse	Greek Word (Lexical Form) / English	Strong's # / Transliteration / Form	Definition & Significance
v.2	**προσκαρτερέω** *devote yourselves*	**G4342** *proskartereō* Pres. Act. Imp. 2nd Pl.	**THAY:** to persevere in, be constantly diligent in (cf. Acts 2:42). **Significance:** Prayer is a persistent, devoted habit, not an occasional act.
v.2	**προσευχή** *prayer*	**G4335** *proseuchē* Dat. Fem. Sg.	**VINE:** the general word for prayer addressed to God. **Significance:** Prayer expresses dependence on God; prayerlessness, independence.
v.2	**γρηγορέω** *keeping alert*	**G1127** *grēgoreō* Pres. Act. Ptc. Nom. Masc. Pl.	**STR:** to keep awake, watch. **VINE:** used by Jesus in Gethsemane (Matt. 26:41). **Significance:** Watch before, during, and after prayer.
v.2	**εὐχαριστία** *thanksgiving*	**G2169** *eucharistia* Dat. Fem. Sg.	**THAY:** gratitude, giving of thanks. **Significance:** The atmosphere of prayer; a thread through the whole letter.
v.3	**θύρα** *door*	**G2374** *thyra* Acc. Fem. Sg.	**VINE:** figuratively, an opportunity (1 Cor. 16:9; 2 Cor. 2:12). **Significance:** God opens doors for the word; we pray rather than push.
v.3	**δέω** *imprisoned*	**G1210** *deō* Perf. Pass. Ind. 1st Sg.	**STR:** to bind, tie, put in chains. **Significance:** Paul's chains resulted from preaching this very mystery.
v.4	**φανερόω** *make clear*	**G5319** *phaneroō* Aor. Act. Subj. 1st Sg.	**THAY:** to make manifest, make plain. **Significance:** Paul prays for clarity in presenting Christ.
v.4	**δεῖ** *ought*	**G1163** *dei* Pres. Act. Ind. 3rd Sg.	**VINE:** it is necessary; denotes compulsion of duty. **Significance:** Preaching was a necessity laid on Paul (1 Cor. 9:16).
v.5	**περιπατέω** *conduct yourselves*	**G4043** *peripateō* Pres. Act. Imp. 2nd Pl.	**VINE:** to walk; to order one's manner of life. **Significance:** Our daily walk is seen by outsiders before our words are heard.
v.5	**ἐξαγοράζω** *making the most of*	**G1805** *exagorazō* Pres. Mid. Ptc. Nom. Masc. Pl.	**THAY:** to buy up, redeem; middle, to buy up for oneself. **Significance:** Buy up every opening for the gospel.
v.5	**καιρός** *opportunity*	**G2540** *kairos*	**VINE:** a fixed or opportune season, not mere chronological time.

Verse	Greek Word (Lexical Form) / English	Strong's # / Transliteration / Form	Definition & Significance
		Acc. Masc. Sg.	**Significance:** The right moment, which may not come again.
v.6	**ἅλας** *salt*	**G217** *halas* Dat. Neut. Sg.	**MRV:** in Greek usage, wit and wholesome flavor in speech. **Significance:** Speech that is wholesome, appealing, and never bland.
v.6	**ἀρτύω** *seasoned*	**G741** *artyō* Perf. Pass. Ptc. Nom. Masc. Sg.	**STR:** to prepare, season. **Significance:** Speech that has been prepared and flavored by grace.
v.6	**ἀποκρίνομαι** *respond*	**G611** *apokrinomai* Pres. Mid./Pass. Inf.	**STR:** to answer, reply. **Significance:** Answer "each person" individually, using the Word.

Grammar key — Cases: Nom. · Gen. · Dat. · Acc. · Voc. | Number: Sg. · Pl. | Gender: Masc. · Fem. · Neut. Verb Mood: Ind. · Imp. · Subj. · Opt. · Inf. · Ptc. | Tense: Pres. · Imperf. · Fut. · Aor. · Perf. · Plpf. | Voice: Act. · Mid. · Pass. | Person: 1st/2nd/3rd Sg./Pl.

Study Questions

Part 1 — From the Commentary

Review prompt	From the commentary
Name the four headings of the passage.	Supplication (v.2), presentation (vv.3–4), implementation (v.5), conversation (v.6).
What three habits describe prayer in v.2?	Devoted, guarded (alert), grateful.
When should we "watch" in prayer?	Before we pray, while we pray, and after we pray.
What did Paul ask the Colossians to pray for him?	An open door for the word and clarity to make the mystery of Christ plain.
What three ingredients describe gospel conversation (v.6)?	Grace (sweetness), salt (seasoning), and knowing how to answer each person (Scripture).

Part 2 — Study Questions

1. Why does the study say that a believer who does not pray is demonstrating independence from God?

> **Leader's answer:** In prayer we call on God to act and express faith in Him. Neglecting prayer implies we can manage without Him, the opposite of "apart from Me you can do nothing" (John 15:5).

2. What does "keeping alert" in prayer involve, and how might it change your prayer life?

> **Leader's answer:** Watching before prayer (prepared, guarding our spirit), during prayer (guarding against wandering thoughts), and after prayer (looking expectantly for God's answer, whether yes, no, or wait).

3. Paul was in chains, yet he asked for an open door rather than an open cell. What does that reveal about his priorities?

> **Leader's answer:** The spread of the gospel mattered more to him than his own comfort or freedom. He saw even his imprisonment as an opportunity (Phil. 1:12–13).

4. What is the difference between "pushing" doors and praying for God to open them?

> **Leader's answer:** Pushing tries to force opportunities by human effort, often with poor results. Praying trusts God, the expert in doors (Rev. 3:7–8), to open the right ones, while we watch and walk through them eagerly.

5. How can speech be both "with grace" and "seasoned with salt"?

> **Leader's answer:** Grace makes it kind and attractive; salt makes it wholesome, flavorful, and sometimes pointed. Together they produce speech that draws people in without diluting the truth, fitted to each person.

Part 3 — Passage Summary

Verses	Theme	Key truth
4:2	Supplication	Devoted, alert, thankful prayer.
4:3–4	Presentation	Pray for an open door and for clear proclamation of the mystery of Christ.
4:5	Implementation	Walk wisely toward outsiders; buy up every opportunity.
4:6	Conversation	Gracious, well-seasoned speech that knows how to answer each person.

⑤ APPLICATION

Closes the study · personal and corporate

1. Make Prayer Your Breathing

Scripture anchor: Colossians 4:2

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, I, and ② Devotional

Prayer that is devoted, alert, and thankful does not happen by accident. It needs a time, a place, and a plan, and then it spills over into the rest of the day as ongoing conversation with God.

Reflection: What most often crowds out your time of prayer?

Practical step: Set a fixed daily time for prayer this week, and end each prayer time with at least three specific thanksgivings.

2. Pray for Open Doors, by Name

Scripture anchor: Colossians 4:3

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, II.A–B and Conclusion

Paul asked for prayer for an open door for the gospel. We can pray the same way for ourselves and for missionaries we support. Ask God to open a specific door with a specific person, and then watch for it.

Reflection: Who are three people in your life who do not yet know Christ?

Practical step: Write their names on a card, pray daily for an open door with each, and watch for the opportunity.

3. Walk Wisely Toward Outsiders

Scripture anchor: Colossians 4:5

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, III; cf. Evans, The Kingdom Agenda (FGR)

Tony Evans often stresses that believers are kingdom representatives in every sphere of life. Our neighbors and coworkers watch our walk long before they listen to our words. Wise conduct, honesty, and kindness open hearts that arguments cannot.

Reflection: What does your daily conduct communicate about Christ to the unbelievers around you?

Practical step: Do one deliberate act of kindness this week for an unbeliever you see regularly.

4. Be Ready to Answer

Scripture anchor: Colossians 4:6; 1 Peter 3:15

Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, IV.C, and ④ Study Question 5

Knowing how to answer each person requires knowing the Word and knowing the person. A short, clear explanation of the gospel, built on verses like John 3:16 and John 5:24, prepares you for the open door when it comes.

Reflection: Could you explain how to receive eternal life in two minutes using Scripture?

Practical step: Write out a simple gospel explanation using John 3:16, 5:24, and 6:47, and practice sharing it with a believer this week.

End of Study · Colossians 4:2–6